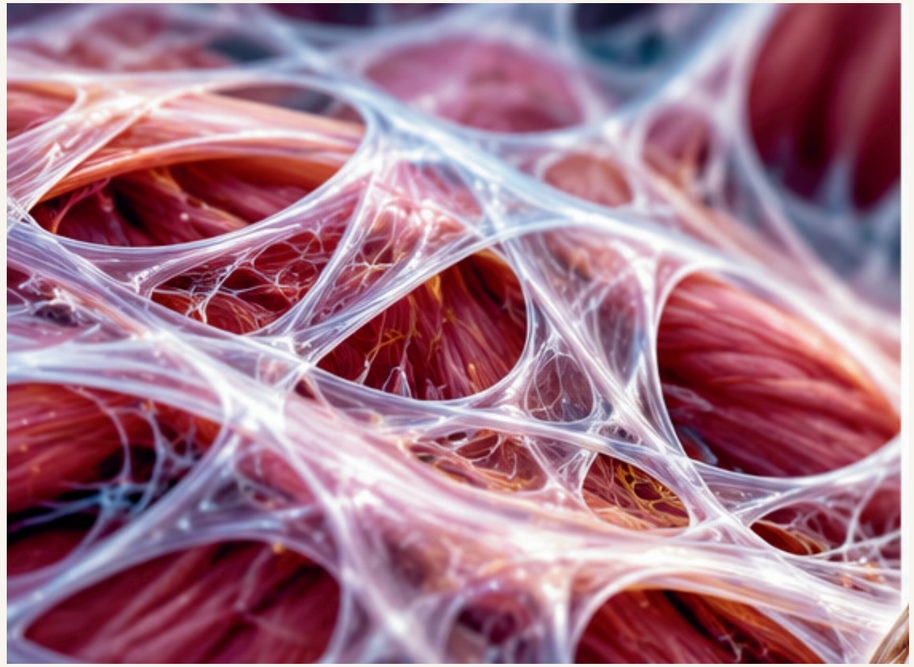
When Stress Becomes Musculoskeletal

Muscular guarding • altered breathing • persistent tension patterns



COMMON PATTERNS

Jaw clenching
Shoulder elevation
Upper-chest breathing

LOWER BODY

Lower-back guarding
Hip/pelvic tension
Protective bracing

FASCIA

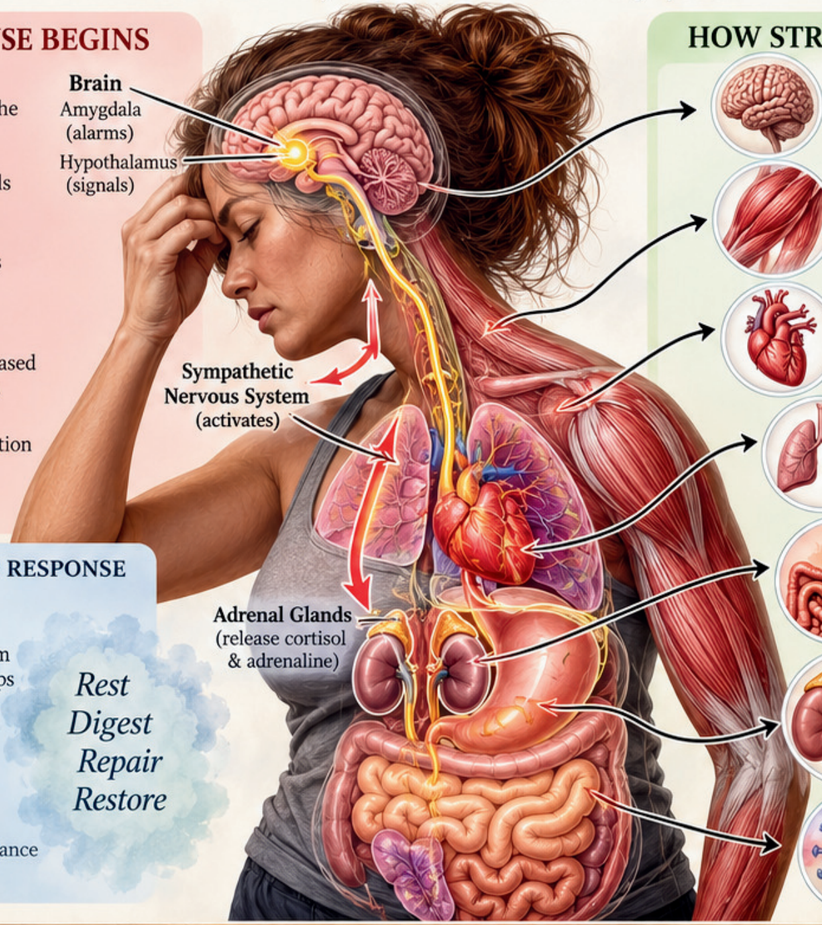
Fascia is richly innervated and interacts with sensory and autonomic processes. Use careful language: persistent tension/bracing—not “emotions literally stored in fascia.”

How Stress Becomes *Physical*

When the mind feels overwhelmed, the body responds. Stress isn't just thought — it's a full-body response that affects every system.

THE STRESS RESPONSE BEGINS

1. A perceived threat or ongoing stress triggers the brain (amygdala).
2. The hypothalamus signals the nervous system.
3. The sympathetic nervous system activates (fight or flight).
4. Stress hormones are released (cortisol and adrenaline).
5. The body prepares for action — even if the stress is emotional or mental.



HOW STRESS AFFECTS THE BODY

BRAIN & MIND
- anxiety, worry, overthinking
- difficulty concentrating
- brain fog, feeling overwhelmed

MUSCLES & FASCIA
- tension (neck, shoulders, back)
- jaw clenching, headaches
- body aches, stiffness
- fascia tightness and restricted movement

HEART & CIRCULATION
- increased heart rate
- higher blood pressure
- feeling jittery or on edge

BREATHING
- shallow breathing
- holding the breath
- shortness of breath

DIGESTIVE SYSTEM
- reduced digestion
- stomach upset, nausea
- bloating, constipation or diarrhea
- decreased nutrient absorption

HORMONES
- elevated cortisol (stress hormone)
- disrupted hormone balance
- fatigue but wired at night
- blood sugar imbalances

IMMUNE SYSTEM
- decreased immune function
- slower healing
- increased inflammation
- more frequent illness

THE PARASYMPATHETIC RESPONSE BRINGS RECOVERY

When the stressor is gone, the parasympathetic nervous system (especially the vagus nerve) helps the body rest, digest, and repair.

- slows heart rate
- supports digestion
- calms the mind
- reduces muscle tension
- supports healing and balance

Rest
Digest
Repair
Restore

THE CYCLE OF CHRONIC STRESS

ONGOING STRESS → mental, emotional, physical or spiritual pressure

BODY STAYS IN A STATE OF ALERT → sympathetic system remains activated

CORTISOL REMAINS ELEVATED → affects sleep, hormones, digestion, immune function and mood

PHYSICAL SYMPTOMS DEVELOP → tension, pain, fatigue, digestive issues, headaches and more

SYMPTOMS CREATE MORE STRESS → which keeps the cycle going

BREAK THE CYCLE

- Identify and address stressors
- Support the nervous system naturally
- Nourish the body
- Support sleep and recovery
- Include calming herbs and lifestyle practices
- Invite God's peace and rest

Herbal Support for Nervous-System Restoration



Think in Herbal Actions—Not “One Herb for Nerves”

RELAXING NERVINES
Lemon balm • chamomile • passionflower • lavender • skullcap

NOURISHING / RESTORATIVE
Oatstraw and gentle nutritive herbs

ADAPTOGENIC SUPPORT
Tulsi and individualized adaptogens

DIGESTIVE NERVINES
Lemon balm • chamomile when tension + digestion overlap

AROMATIC / CIRCULATORY
Lavender • rosemary as appropriate

Featured Herbs I

Action • pattern • caution

LEMON BALM
ACTION: Relaxing nervine / digestive
PATTERN: Tension + digestive uneasiness
CAUTION: Sedative/thyroid/medication context

OATSTRAW
ACTION: Traditional nourishing nervine
PATTERN: Depleted, daily nutritive pattern
CAUTION: Food/gluten sourcing as relevant

CHAMOMILE
ACTION: Relaxing nervine / digestive
PATTERN: Tension + GI discomfort
CAUTION: Asteraceae allergy; interactions

TULSI
ACTION: Adaptogenic traditional use
PATTERN: Prolonged stress demand
CAUTION: Glucose/bleeding/medication context

PASSIONFLOWER
ACTION: Relaxing nervine
PATTERN: Restlessness / sleep support
CAUTION: Sedation; perioperative caution



Featured Herbs II

Action • pattern • caution

LAVENDER
ACTION: Aromatic relaxing herb
PATTERN: Calming ritual / sleep support
CAUTION: Product + route matter

SKULLCAP
ACTION: Traditional relaxing nervine
PATTERN: Tension / difficulty settling
CAUTION: Quality sourcing; sedation

ROSEMARY
ACTION: Aromatic / traditional circulatory
PATTERN: Aromatic support; topical/culinary
CAUTION: Not a substitute for neuro evaluation

HORSETAIL
ACTION: Mineral-rich traditional herb
PATTERN: Connective-tissue/nutritive teaching
CAUTION: Species, kidney/medication context

CALENDULA
ACTION: Traditional tissue/topical herb
PATTERN: Comfort preparations / skin support
CAUTION: Asteraceae sensitivity



Activated or Depleted?

Both may say: “I’m overwhelmed.” They may not need the same formula.

WOMAN A — ACTIVATED

“I can’t turn it off.”

Restless • tense • racing thoughts • digestive butterflies • difficulty falling asleep

HERBAL THINKING
Relaxing nervines + regulation + sleep support



WOMAN B — DEPLETED

“I have nothing left.”

Exhausted • under-nourished • poor sleep • long-term caregiving • low reserve

HERBAL THINKING
Nourishment + nutritive herbs + food + minerals + restorative support



Match the Herb to the Pattern

Clinical herbal thinking

RESTLESS + RACING THOUGHTS	RELAXING NERVINE
NERVOUS + DIGESTIVE DISCOMFORT	NERVINE + DIGESTIVE SUPPORT
TENSE + MUSCULAR GUARDING	RELAXING NERVINE + APPROPRIATE TOPICAL/MUSCULOSKELETAL SUPPORT
DEPLETED + CHRONICALLY STRESSED	NOURISHMENT + NUTRITIVE HERBS + NUTRITIONAL FOUNDATION
POOR SLEEP	IDENTIFY WHY FIRST → APPROPRIATE NIGHTTIME SUPPORT
PROLONGED STRESS DEMAND	CONSIDER INDIVIDUALIZED ADAPTOGENIC SUPPORT
NEUROPATHIC SYMPTOMS	EVALUATE CAUSE FIRST—DO NOT ASSUME STRESS

Nervous-System Wellness Support

Foundations that make the herbal plan stronger

HYDRATION + MINERALS
Adequate fluids and appropriate electrolyte/mineral intake

REST + DECOMPRESSION
Recovery periods, reduced overload, quiet transition rituals

SLEEP SUPPORT
Identify barriers; use herbs only as part of the larger sleep picture

LOWER LUMBAR + FASCIA
Movement, heat when appropriate, bodywork, topical comfort support

GENTLE “DETOX” SUPPORT
Hydration • fiber • regular elimination • normal liver/kidney function—not pathogen cleansing

Herbal Preparations & Recipes I

Simple preparations the overwhelmed woman may actually use

NERVOUS-SYSTEM TEA

2 parts oatstraw
1 part lemon balm
1 part chamomile
½ part lavender

Covered infusion; individualize.

MINERAL / NOURISHING BROTH

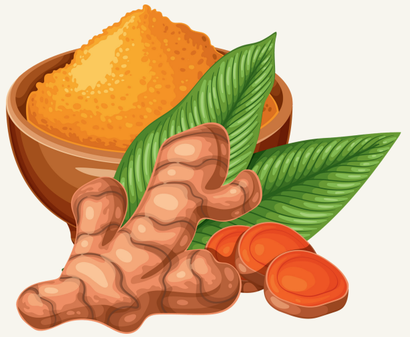
Vegetables + appropriate nutritive herbs
Hydration + food-based nourishment
Choose ingredients for the individual.

GOLDEN MILK

Plant milk + turmeric + optional tolerated spices
Comforting evening ritual—not a neurologic treatment.







Herbal Preparations & Recipes II

Sleep + muscular comfort

SLEEP-SUPPORT TEA

Chamomile • passionflower • lemon balm • lavender
Skullcap when appropriate

Review sedation, medications, pregnancy/lactation and individual sensitivities.



LOWER-LUMBAR COMFORT SALVE

Calendula • rosemary • appropriate topical herbs in a carrier-oil/beeswax base

For muscular comfort and massage—not for repairing damaged nerves or treating spinal disease.



Formulate Instead of Following a Recipe

The recipe is the starting point. The individual determines the formula.

1
Primary pattern?

2
Activated or depleted?

3
Body systems involved?

4
Medications?

5
Allergies?

6
Constitution?

7
Nutritional status?

8
Best preparation?

9
Contraindications?

10
Need referral?

Educational Case Study — Presentation

Chronic stress + physical caregiving demands + lower-lumbar dysfunction

CONTEXT

Woman in her 50s
Caregiving / health-aide work
Heavy physical + emotional workload
Chronic stress

PRESENTATION

Lower-lumbar discomfort/restriction
Difficulty lifting/twisting
Poor tolerance of prolonged sitting, standing or one position

CLINICAL LENS

Muscular guarding?
Mechanical strain?
Nutritional/sleep depletion?
Neurologic or systemic red flags?
Need referral?

Educational Case Study — Support & Outcome

Wellness support alongside appropriate medical care

SUPPORT

Hydration • nourishment • rest
Herbal nervous-system support
Topical comfort support
Appropriate movement
Biofeedback used only as a non-diagnostic wellness tool

REPORTED / OBSERVED CHANGES

Improved mobility
Improved flexibility
Better sitting/standing tolerance
Lower-lumbar comfort
Daily function + calmness

SCOPE

Suspected spinal infection, neurologic disease, progressive weakness or other concerning findings require conventional medical evaluation.

Practical Daily Nervous-System Support

Simple enough to live

MORNING
Light exposure • hydration • nourishment

DAYTIME
Regular meals • movement • appropriate tea • breaks

TRANSITION
Breathing • decompression • reduce overstimulation

EVENING
Consistent bedtime • calming routine • sleep support when appropriate

ONGOING
Reassess symptoms • nutrition • medications • red flags • response to herbs

Final Encouragement

You do not have to carry everything alone.

- The overwhelmed woman does not need shame.
- She needs support, nourishment, nervous-system restoration, emotional safety, rest and peace.
- Sometimes restoration begins when the body is given permission and opportunity to stop bracing against life.

“Come unto me, all ye that labour and are heavy laden, and I will give you rest.”

Matthew 11:28 KJV



FREE

Worksheet



ASK ME

Nervous System Herbalist Specialist- A Full Course is available in the PENothecary Learning HUB.

THE OVERWHELMED WOMAN DOESN'T ALWAYS NEED ANOTHER CALMING HERB.

Sometimes she needs nourishment.
Sometimes she needs sleep.
Sometimes she needs minerals.
Sometimes she needs the stressor addressed.
Sometimes she needs medical evaluation.

Ask: What is happening in this woman?
What does her nervous system need?
What is the safest, simplest, most appropriate herbal support?